wanted to leak. He also thought she could communicate it securely.

Poitras quickly responded to Snowden's first e-mail. After exchanging numerous encrypted e-mails during the next few months, Snowden and Poitras gained each other's trust. Snowden suggested she reach out to Greenwald, and in April 2013, Poitras and Greenwald met in New York to discuss what Poitras had learned. They agreed the individual contacting her—who had

"MY LIFE JUST CHANGED"

In January 2013, Laura Poitras received an odd e-mail. A stranger was asking for her encryption key to send her a confidential e-mail. Curious, she did as the person asked. The stranger promised he or she had sensitive information to share. Before long, the stranger was sending Poitras encrypted e-mail messages about secret surveillance programs run by the US government. Some of the programs were familiar to Poitras, but others she had never heard of. "I thought, O.K., if this is true, my life just changed," Poitras told a reporter. "It was staggering, what he claimed to know and be able to provide."[1]

Poitras was not Snowden's first choice as a media contact. The month before e-mailing Poitras, he had sent a similar e-mail to Glenn Greenwald, a journalist with the *Guardian* newspaper. But Greenwald ignored Snowden's request, partly because of his confusion with using encryption and also because Snowden's e-mails struck him as too ambiguous. "He kept harassing me," Greenwald said in an interview, "but at some point [Snowden] just got frustrated, so he went to Laura."[2]

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